

Chapter One

Silencer screwed on. Knives ready. Harness is... secure to me, secure to the spike I drilled into the mortar, a few feet from the hatch.

Nazi-Chicago. The sky is moonless, soaked with radiation. Pure darkness. It's crumbling under the sheer weight of fallout, with certain sections already pluming to an uncaring city.

When one is up on the highest rooftop of the city, in the thick of the miasma, there is only isotropy. The roof's outline, one large square, is detectable only due to its being a duller black than everything else. The cityscape, far below, I can only sense, in the same way one can detect things in a pure dark room.

All to say, my work is made a little easier. I shove my trench coat's collar further around my neck, prop up the cloth covering the lower half of my face, and, with a hand laced in Muay Thai ropes, I grip the stretch of hemp attached to the lower back of my harness.

I step up to the roof's edge, the toes of my boots hanging over. The air is still and silent. I take a breath, bristle against the inevitable burn in my nostrils and throat. And then, I tip over.

Into an abyss, I fall free, my footsteps pattering lightly against a building side that looks no different than its roof.

Air whistles. Minutes pass. Pat, pat, pat.

Then, a balcony emerges. Something that seems like imagination at first. Then, a murky impression. Then, a half-oval of flags, with two little figures idling in its center. Elite Soldiers. The balcony rises, rises, rises...

I cinch my covered fingers, my covered palm, on the hemp. I kick off the wall, twirl through the murk, slash the rope, and plop to the floor. Ink. My coat follows in a loose circle. The two Soldiers take a second to realize something black has morphed from the gloom, and then they see that the thing wears a trench coat and has a covered face. Their terrified squeals, mechanized through the helmets, are like death rattles.

But, given their Elite status, instincts kick in. Their semi-autos, which were held across their breastplates, become couched beneath their arms, and blinding fire ruptures the silence, laces the stones. It's too late, though. I'm already between them with my pistol drawn. Two easy gunshots into two armored knees, and two gleaming plates of black explode, the bones jolting unnaturally. The Soldiers scream as they fall to their knees. They bring their sidearms forth and fire, bring their knives out and slash, all in a fury. But, I am the breeze, flowing between them, flowing around each attack, moving round and round. I kick on right between the shoulder blades, shoving him to the floor, suffering a minor shock to my own knee. The other fires at me, but I've grabbed his sidearm's muzzle, sent the bullet to the clouds. I flick my other hand, popping a stiletto into my palm, and delivering its point beneath the helm and through the fleshy neck.

Quick deaths are all the mercy I can afford right now.

The other has recovered. Propped on one elbow, he fires, but I'm already spiraling over him. I swing my knee beside his ear and stab the bloodied knife into his neck as well. The thing with armor as intricate as theirs—there isn't much room for creativity. A halo of blood plumes around the Soldier's helm.

My stomach cringes, forgetting itself.

I carry on. Where the balcony meets the fortress wall, a square of light awaits, its integrity crumbling upon impact with the open air. I pause for a moment, right in the doors threshold. It's an interesting sight, the fingers of lamplight and sickly zephyr lacing together, both negating each other's stamina.

Then, I'm in. To my right is a row of busts flanked by wartime paintings. The busts whizz by until I arrive at the one depicting Martin Bormann. He had a mustache in this world's history. Interesting.

Alright, Stahl. You better be right about this. I clamp Bormann's ears and push in opposite directions. The bust twists with a resigned groan. When the eyes are glowering towards at the four o'clock position, the bust clicks to a stop. One edge of the painting that backdrops it pops from its magnetic clamps.

Into the rabbit hole I go. The bust, creaking its old bones, swivels back to its initial position.

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The fortress thrums with noise. Men shout. Boots stomp. Safeties click off. Machines of war hum.

I peer through slits of light as towering, reinforced metal doors screech, revealing a great hallway. Elites clad in glistening black, with tinted visors and blood-red swastikas emblazoned on their breastplates, stand at attention on either side. A man and a woman stride between them and enter. The doors are closed behind them.

The man speaks in German, and his voice is oh-so familiar. “The generator halls?”

“Fortified,” replies the woman.

“By a whole battalion?”

“Two.”

“And our perimeter?”

“Moated by an army. Thermals monitoring the parapets.”

“Have lights cast upon them too. Make it daylight.” The Victor floats past her with hands clasped behind him. “This room. It’s been scoured?”

“Gordon himself inspected it.”

“And he—”

“Reported downstairs. Yes.”

I look down at Gordon, who’s snuggled between my knee and the closet’s corner.

The Victor lets out a breath at last and speaks with a dismissive tone. “That will be all, then, Frieda. Thank you.”

“Uhm, sir. Are you sure you wouldn’t like...” Her voice lowers. “Some company?”

“No.” Frieheled doesn’t move. “I’ve warned you of our enemy’s capabilities.”

“He’s one man.” Something in the Victor’s countenance makes her gulp. “I’ll let myself out.”

A door clicks closed. I count to five Mississippi, and then silently ululate the muscles around my trachea, warming them up. The Victor is turned away from me, facing the room's entrance, ready. Or not ready, depending on how you look at it.

I slink out.

A kaleidoscope of torchlight sprays onto a travertine floor. It glints brilliantly off the medallions decorating his forest green uniform, form-fitted so tightly it could be a second skin. Poor guy. The cost power brings.

His hair—or, more accurately, his wig—is thick, slick, and the color of chocolate. Like the other wealthy Nazis, he wears a wig to cover his bald head. Except he isn't balding. He probably shaves his head every day in order to maintain appearances.

I aim my sidearm at the head's nape. He fidgets from foot to foot. I get it. The not-knowing. It's enough to drive a Victor mad.

Maybe I could speak up this time instead of waiting. Perhaps it'd trigger a different fear response. But, no. I won't turn callous at the last minute. I won't let months of work diminish my carefully sculpted reputation. This method is tried and true.

My Victor spins at last and sees a pupil of shadow burned against a visage of luxuries. Fear—great, sickening fear—flickers across his face. It transforms to a sneer so rapidly that if I wasn't also a Victor, I wouldn't have noticed.

Frightening another me. Still a surreal feeling.

"You—"

"*Quiet,*" I gutturize.

He bristles at the accent. "Who sent you? Lehrman? Stahl?" I give him my blankest stare.

“What am I? Number ten? Eleven?” False confidence. I know it. *Does he know I know it?* “Hm. How did you sneak in, *Victor*?” He saunters toward me.

He knows how. Lots of questions.

He’s not searching for answers. Of course not. But, I must wait.

And wait.

Cool metal coils around my neck. The space between moments, between precision and pull, reveals itself. I shove my fingers beneath the chain and throw all my weight forward. The chain snaps, and I feel someone light-weighted flying. *Paramour number two, perhaps?* In the matter of an instant, I jab a hand into my coat, find a hilt, and stab a glittering blade into the air. There’s a low crunch as it embeds itself into a mop of dirty-blond hair. The woman, lithe and all in black, flops unceremoniously to the floor. A red stain spreads through that blondeness.

I know what I’d do if I were the other living person in this room. Indeed, a glint of metal catches the corner of my eye. But he’s slow. I whip out my sidearm and fire through the pistol-wielding hand. “Gah!” cries the Victor as gun and bits of finger spray from the wound.

Even though I had a silencer attached, the chamber vibrates at the shot. Tension grips me. I watch the doors, but no noise or movement follows.

He’s fallen to his knees, cradling his hand. The injury is not serious. Eyes hot with rage burn into me. “*You*” he growls, “and all of those you care for. They’ll be found and butchered like the animals—”

“*Enough*,” I rumble. “*We both know who I am.*”

“Do we now, savage?”

“*Savage?*” I look around, at all four corners of the room. Let intelligence seep into my

eyes.

A moment passes. "You're a Victor, then?"

"Fortunately not." I slip a hand into my trench coat, and from my palm I unfurl a garland of blood. Laboratory vials, swimming with it, connected by a singular string. Sharpied on tape are the world numbers associated with each vial.

The Victor frowns at the vials. He remains unconvinced of the notion that one who's not a Victor could best him.

I'll teach him a painful, if not fraudulent lesson.

"The multiversal trespasser," he croons. *"The Demon. Torturer of Victors, asker of questions. I could shout now. Ha! I could shout now, and you wouldn't shoot me." Because I am, in fact, a Victor?*

I shoot him, and he twitches onto his back. He might lose movement of that shoulder for some time. When he looks at me, writ on his eyes is nothing but truth. He's convinced.

That's all it took. Fool.

No. Not a fool. He only need be reminded of the cold. I clench his uniform, wrinkling the pristine fit, and haul him back to his knees.

"The rumors of me. Who spoke of them?" I ask.

"The Victors you tortured," he whispers. Takes me a second to realize he's not answering the question. "They're said to have returned to their home worlds, squandering their accomplishments. That's not true, is it? You killed them." *Not quite.* I nod and pocket the blood garland. "Is my death certain?" he asks.

"No."

“Long as I answer your infamous questions, right? Cabals, keys, all that nonsense?”

“First things first.” I toss over a leather pouch. It fumbles from the Victor’s trembling fingers. He keeps his eyes on me as he stoops and carefully unzips it. Inside is a syringe full of a clear liquid. He rolls it thoughtfully between his fingers.

Then, he chuckles ruefully, rises to his feet, clutching his wounded shoulder.

I wait for his move.

“How arrogant must you be to play at a monster in a realm of polymaths?” he drawls.

“I’ll not let you grope me in my sleep. My death shall not be prolonged.” He draws a bejeweled dagger from his scabbard.

“I don’t care for such things.” I let a new knife slip into my hand. *“The drug will make you quiet. If you will not take it, I’ll cut your tongue and have you write your answers.”*

He regards the syringe again, curses, and slides the needle into his neck.

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